

MATH356 (Honours Probability) Notes

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1 September 1: Introduction to Probability Spaces

1.1 Motivation

Consider a fair six-sided die. Let D be the face that shows after a roll. We call D a **random variable**.

Suppose we roll a 2, i.e. $D = 2$. Then the probability of rolling this 2, denoted $\mathbb{P}(D = 2)$ is $1/6$ as we know very well (in fact $\mathbb{P}(D = k) = 1/6$ for any $k \in \{1, \dots, 6\}$).

Suppose now we roll the same die twice, with the face showing after the first roll denoted D_1 and the second roll D_2 . We ask ourselves the probability of first rolling a 2, then a 3 (i.e. $\mathbb{P}(D_1 = 2, D_2 = 3)$). Again, as we know very well, this probability is $1/36$.

Let us now consider two unfair six-sided dice. The first die has $\mathbb{P}(D = 4) = \mathbb{P}(D = 5) = \mathbb{P}(D = 6) = 2/9$ and $\mathbb{P}(D = 1) = \mathbb{P}(D = 2) = \mathbb{P}(D = 3) = 1/9$, while the second die has $\mathbb{P}(D = 4) = \mathbb{P}(D = 5) = \mathbb{P}(D = 6) = 1/9$ and $\mathbb{P}(D = 1) = \mathbb{P}(D = 2) = \mathbb{P}(D = 3) = 2/9$.

Let us blindly choose one of these unfair dice and roll it twice. We ask, what is $\mathbb{P}(D = 1)$? We don't know which die we chose, but we know that if we chose the first die, the probability of rolling a 1 is $1/9$, while if we chose the second die, the probability of rolling a 1 is $2/9$. We have a $1/2$ probability of choosing either die, so by laws of conditional probability and independent events (we will see these later), we have:

$$\mathbb{P}(D = 1) = \frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{2}{9} + \frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{9} = \frac{1}{6}$$

In fact, as with the fair die, $\mathbb{P}(D = k) = 1/6$ for any $k \in \{1, \dots, 6\}$.

Example 1.1.1. Consider the same two unfair dice as above. What is $\mathbb{P}(D_1 = 1, D_2 = 1)$? In other words, what is the probability that both dice show a 1?

Solution. Suppose we chose the first unfair die (the probability of doing so is $1/2$). Then the probability of rolling a 1 twice is $1/9 \cdot 1/9 = 1/81$. If we chose the second die (again, the probability of doing so is $1/2$), then the probability of rolling a 1 twice is $2/9 \cdot 2/9 = 4/81$. Since we have a $1/2$ probability of choosing either die, we have that:

$$\mathbb{P}(D_1 = 1, D_2 = 1) = \left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{9} \cdot \frac{1}{9} \right) \left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{2}{9} \cdot \frac{2}{9} \right) = \frac{5}{162} \quad \checkmark$$

This example may have been difficult to follow and that is okay. Many concepts such as “independent events” or “conditional probability” may be novel. The goal of this course is to learn what those topics are, among others:

- What is an event?
- What is a random variable?
- How can we model the outcome of an experiment?
- And many more!

1.2 Introduction to Probability Spaces

Definition 1.2.2

A **probability space** is a triple $(\Omega, \mathcal{F}, \mathbb{P})$, where Ω is the **sample space**, $\mathcal{F}$ is all subsets of Ω and $\mathbb{P}$ is the **probability measure**.

For any probability space, $\mathbb{P}$ must satisfy the **Kolmogorov Axioms**, which are:

1. If $A \in \mathcal{F}$, then $\mathbb{P}(A) \in [0, 1]$.
2. $\mathbb{P}(\emptyset) = 0$ and $\mathbb{P}(\Omega) = 1$.
3. If $(A_n)_{n \geq 1}$ are disjoint events, then $\mathbb{P}(\bigcup_{n \geq 1} A_n) = \mathbb{P}(\sum_{n \geq 1} A_n)$.

We call the elements in $\mathcal{F}$ **events**, such as rolling a 1, or flipping heads on a coin.

$\mathbb{P}$ assigns probabilities to events, with $\mathbb{P}: \mathcal{F} \rightarrow [0, 1]$.

Example 1.2.3. Let us revisit the fair six-sided die. Here we define $\Omega := \{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$, $\mathcal{F} := 2^\Omega$ (the power set, or set of all subsets of Ω), and $\mathbb{P}(E) := \frac{|E|}{6}$.

If we roll the fair die twice, then now $\Omega := [6] \times [6]$, $\mathcal{F} := 2^\Omega$ and $\mathbb{P}(E) := \frac{|E|}{36}$.

Example 1.2.4. Model tossing a fair coin 3 times. What about infinitely many times? Can you model the unfair dice from before?

Solution. Left as an exercise (for next class).

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